A hybrid ballpoint pen

Walter Hall introduces us to hybrid pens made up from a collection of components

WALTER HALL

Walter Hall is a woodturner who has specialised in making pens and pencils for more than 20 years. Based on the beautiful Northumberland coast in the UK, Walter sells his bespoke pens and pencils through local craft centres and via his website.

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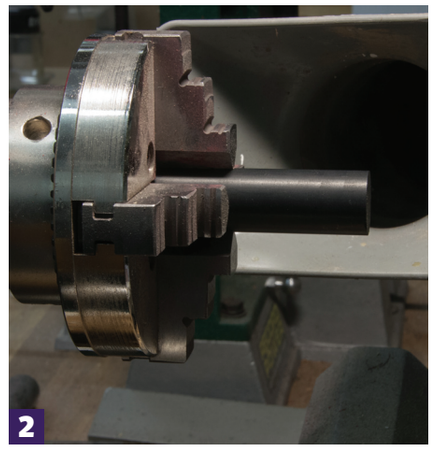
PHOTOGRAPHS BY WALTER HALL

What is he on about now, you may be asking yourself. We have had modified kits and kitless pens, but what exactly is a hybrid? Well, this pen is certainly not just a few modifications to a standard kit, but neither does it qualify as kitless since it makes use of the mechanism from a Sierra-style twist pen, and a tube and the clip and associated parts from a flat top kit. Now let me be clear, I did not buy two kits and throw away the rest of the parts just to make something a bit different.

The mechanism was purchased from Beaufort Ink specifically for this project, while the Flat Top parts came from my scrap box of components (from past, well, let's just call them 'projects' that did not come out as intended). I guess most pen makers who have reached the stage of wanting to move on from kit assembling will have accumulated just such a collection. The front end of the pen, housing the mechanism and the refill, is made from black Ebonite while the barrel is bloodwood (*Brosimum rubescens*).

1



2

EQUIPMENT USED

Pen mechanism
Flat Top component parts
Suitable blanks, e.g. Ebonite and bloodwood
Depth stop
Board with 'V' grooves
Scroll chuck with engineers' jaws
Keyless chuck
Callipers
Drill bits and taps to suit size of components
Disk sander with jig or barrel trimmer
Scriber or hacksaw
Files
Abrasive cloth
Epoxy glue
Cutting tool of choice
Finish of choice, e.g. cyanoacrylate
Micro-Mesh and other polishing compounds

1 The first job is to cut the Ebonite to length. This needs to be just a fraction longer than the 65mm finished size of the component to allow for trimming. Cutting round pen blanks on the band saw is not an alarmingly dangerous activity, but the blank can turn when it contacts the blade or get caught between blade and fence if the fence is used as a depth stop. Either of these things could result in fingers being drawn towards the blade, so use a depth stop that stops just short of the blade and attaches to the fence so there is clearance for the separated part. Also use a board with 'V' grooves against which the blank can be held to stop it from revolving

2 Mount the blank in a scroll chuck using engineers' jaws. I prefer to use a collet chuck for accuracy but the blank, at 20mm in diameter, is too large for the 13mm capacity of the collet chuck I have available. I could, of course, turn it down to a suitable size first

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